

Okay, so your assortment of portable devices—PDA, digital diary etc—make you feel you're the King of computing-on-the-go, but haven't you ever wished you could do more with these devices? That you could play more than chess or do more than read an e-book or listen to MP3 music when you're bored with that in-flight movie? That you could go beyond just editing of your Word and Excel files on your PDA? That you wouldn't miss your laptop so much?

Handheld devices already let you take notes, schedule your day, catch up on e-mail messages or plug in headphones to listen to MP3s during your daily jog. You can even use them as a stand-in for times when you cannot—or do not—want to take your laptop with you. But they still fall short of being the complete companion for your computing needs on the road.

This void for a portable device that's somewhere between a laptop and a desktop in computing power and is still small, is being filled by a slew of futuristic portables. These new devices incorporate technologies that integrate several functions into an all-in-one device that's also easy to operate.

## Market Overview

A processing powerhouse that sits on your lap is no longer a dream. Some laptops available today are real powerhouses in themselves, with processing speeds as high as 2.4 GHz, with 512 MB DDR RAM, and they come with DVD-Writers and other matching peripherals. Laptops once considered to be worthy only for top-of-the-line marketing teams are now becoming a reality for most professionals on the move. Although many vendors are still pushing Celeron-based PCs, some vendors such as Toshiba, HP, Sony, ACi and Fujitsu have geared themselves up with the latest technology and are offering Centrino-based PCs, along with an option of tablet functionalities.

Today, mobile PC technology is moving at a brisk pace. Features such as support for Bluetooth and wireless networking support are no longer a futuristic dream. Most users who've used a desktop for a couple of years and have got hooked to it now want to move on to a laptop. In

sync with this, vendors have been reducing laptop prices to make them affordable to all, with varying levels of success.

Now there's an alternative. The 'desknote', which is more of a laptop but big enough to replace a desktop, has started gaining momentum, largely due to the cost factor. A chief feature of the desknote is that it does not come with a built-in battery—the same is available as an optional extra. One of the prominent brands available in India is the Kobian desknote, which costs from Rs 45,000 to Rs 55,000 depending on the model.

Technological development in this segment has been tremendous, and the emphasis is on making products lighter on power. Intel, with its SpeedStep technology for mobile processors, promises longer battery life. Transmeta's Crusoe processors consume the least power and are specifically designed for mobile devices. AMD uses its PowerNow technology for longer battery life.

In the last couple of months we've seen rivals such as IBM, Toshiba and HP battling it out.

All of them launched new models, particularly with the Centrino platform targeted at the premium segment. Celeron-based notebooks form a major percentage of notebooks sold in the entry-level segment, where there is a large market for refurbished notebooks. These notebooks, which are often backed by service and support, provide good value for money at prices that range between Rs 30,000 and Rs 40,000.

With increasing demand, vendors are also looking at providing more flexible solutions. Some, such as HP, Acer and Wipro, are even considering setting up assembly plants in India.

Among handhelds, a trend observed is that of providing solutions rather than a product. Hence a couple of vendors have started concentrating on software development. With bigger brands such as Sony, HP and Palm failing to make an impact on the higher price bracket, vendors such as Pushpam have started targeting the government sector to gain momentum.

Overall, the mobile segment is seeing increasing demand, particularly in low-cost solutions, and is poised to attain new heights in the coming months.



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